

Switzerland



A mountainous republic at the center of western Europe but politically separate from it.

1291 After the Habsburgs curtail the autonomy of the Swiss cantons, Unterwalden, Schwyz, and Uri set up the Perpetual League to pursue Swiss liberty.

1499 Now joined by other cantons, the Swiss succeed in gaining virtual independence with the Habsburgs retaining only a titular role.

1648 Peace of Westphalia ending the 30 Years War recognizes the full independence of the Swiss Confederation.

1798 Invaded by Napoleon, who creates Helvetic Republic, which lasts until 1803.

1815 Congress of Vienna after Napoleon's defeat confirms Swiss independence and establishes its neutrality. Geneva, Neuchâtel, and Valais join the Swiss Confederation.

1848 New constitution gives central government more powers, but guarantees the cantons' powers.

1857 King of Prussia renounces territorial claims over Neuchâtel.

1874 Referendum established as important decision-making tool in government.

1914–18 Plays humanitarian role in World War I.

1919 Proportional representation ensures future political stability.

1920 Joins League of Nations, based in Geneva.

1939–45 Switzerland remains neutral in World War II and refuses to join the UN in 1945.



The Red Cross

This field ambulance bearing the Red Cross was used in World War I. The foundation of the Red Cross in Geneva in 1863 by Swiss social activist Henri Dunant, and the signing of the 1864 Geneva Convention on the conduct of war, made Geneva a center of international diplomacy.

1959 Founder member of European Free Trade Area. The present four-party coalition comes to power.

1967 Right-wing groups make electoral gains, campaigning to restrict entry of foreign workers.

1971 Most women granted the right to vote in federal elections.

1986 Referendum opposes joining UN. Immigrant numbers are restricted.

1988 Kopp resigns over allegedly violating secrecy of information laws. She is acquitted in 1990, but the case reveals that the Public Prosecutor's office holds secret files on 200,000 people. Violent protests. State security laws amended.

1992 Joins IMF and World Bank.

1998 \$1.25 billion compensation paid to relatives of Holocaust victims whose funds were deposited in Swiss banks.

1999 Ruth Dreifuss is first woman president.

2000 Referendum endorses close trade links with EU, but full membership is rejected in a referendum in 2001.

2002 Abortion decriminalized. Switzerland joins UN.

2009 Switzerland announces it will relax banking secrecy laws.

«306–07 The Napoleonic Wars

Liechtenstein



A tiny principality wedged between Austria and Switzerland, with which it has close ties.

1342 Graf Hartmann von Montfort becomes owner of the Castle of Vaduz and in 1396, still under the control of the Montfort family, Vaduz is confirmed as a fief of the Holy Roman Empire.

1416 The last Montfort count bequeaths Vaduz to Baron von Brandis of Emmental, who in 1419 also gains control of the domain of Schellenberg to the north of Vaduz.

1719 Following the purchase of Vaduz by Prince Johann Adam Andreas von Liechtenstein in 1712, the Holy Roman Emperor Charles VI raises the status of Vaduz and Schellenberg to that of an independent principality.

1806 Liechtenstein declares its full sovereignty as the Holy Roman Empire is

dissolved. A Rheinbund league of German princes, which is formed at the suggestion of Napoleon Bonaparte, does not outlast Napoleon, and in 1815 Liechtenstein joins the German Confederation, remaining a member until its dissolution in 1866.

1852 A customs union is formed with Austria and the Austrian currency becomes the legal tender. This lasts until the dismemberment of the Austro-Hungarian Empire in 1918.

1866 Liechtenstein formally achieves independence following the dissolution of the German Confederation.

1868 Liechtenstein's standing army is abolished.

1921 New constitution grants joint authority to a hereditary prince and a Landtag (parliament). Liechtenstein adopts Swiss currency.

1923 Customs union with Switzerland.

1938 Prince Franz Josef II maintains neutrality during World War II.

1990 Joins UN.

1995 Joins European Economic Area and World Trade Organization.

1997 End of the coalition dominant since 1938. Mario Frick now heads a Fatherland Union government.

2000 Swiss army inadvertently invades Liechtenstein when a training mission gets lost and crosses an unmarked border.

2003 Referendum votes to give Prince Hans-Adam II sweeping political powers.

Slovenia



The richest republic of the former Yugoslavia was also the first to declare independence.

14 CE The Roman general Gaius Octavius (later Emperor Augustus) founds a city on the site of Ljubljana.

900 CE The Magyars take Ljubljana, which passes into the hands of the dukes of Carinthia in the 12th century.

1277 The Habsburgs control the region; while under Austrian rule Ljubljana becomes center for Slovenian nationalism.

1809 Napoleon captures the territories held by Austria and reorganizes them into the Illyrian Provinces, with Ljubljana as the seat of government. Serfdom is abolished and the peasants are given their lands. Austria regains control in 1814.

1855 Slovenian nationalists develop a cooperative movement in the countryside that provides credit and other services to help Slovenes break free of Germanic institutions.

1867 Austria-Hungary reorganizes the Slavs under its control after its defeat by Prussia. Slovenes are linked to Austria.

1918 Serbian Prince Alexander unites Serbia, Montenegro, Croatia, Bosnia, and Slovenia into the Kingdom of Serbs, Croats, and Slovenes, after the defeat of the Central Powers. Alexander becomes king in August 1921.

1929 Alexander imposes a dictatorship to end Serbian, Croatian, and Slovene nationalism and renames the country Yugoslavia. However his rule merely increases Serbian domination, bureaucracy, and repression by the police. Alexander is assassinated in 1934.

1941–45 Germany occupies Slovenia in World War II and divides it with Italy.

1945 Josef Tito's communists take power in Yugoslavia. When he dies in 1980, Yugoslavia begins to fall apart.

1989 Parliament confirms the right to secede and calls multiparty elections.

1990 Control over the army asserted; a referendum approves secession.

1991 Independence declared as Slovenia is the first Yugoslav republic to secede. The Yugoslav federal army repelled. Fewer than 100 die in the clashes.

1993 Joins IMF and IBRD.



Slovenians celebrate

Upon seceding from Yugoslavia on June 25, 1991, Slovenia was invaded by the federal army and a 10-day war ensued. Armed resistance, roadblocks, and desertions put an end to the attack.

2004 Slovenia joins the EU and NATO.

2007 Slovenia is first of the new EU member states to adopt the euro.

2010 Referendum backs international arbitration on border dispute with Croatia.

«262–63 The 30 Years War

Austria



Once a dominant force in Central Europe, and since 1995 a member of the European Union.

15 BCE Austria south of the Danube is conquered by the Romans and incorporated within the Roman Empire.